

Siren lacertina

Greater siren



Length 20–35 in (50–90 cm)
Habit Wholly aquatic
Breeding Early spring season
Status Least concern

Location E. and S.E. USA



Sirens are among the largest amphibians in North America. There are 2 species, both with long, eel-like bodies and only one pair of legs, behind their feathery external gills. The greater siren is usually gray or olive-brown,

and this color provides it with good camouflage in the muddy water of ponds, lakes, and slow-flowing rivers. This siren spends the day resting on the bottom, but at night forages for food, either crawling over mud or sediment, or swimming with a sinuous movement of its tail. Like most amphibians, greater sirens are almost entirely carnivorous—snails, insect larvae, and small fish making up most of their food. However, during droughts, they encase themselves in mud cocoons, and can survive without food for up to 2 years. Greater sirens lay their eggs in early spring. When their larvae hatch, they are little bigger than most other amphibian tadpoles.



feathery external gills

Pseudobranchius striatus

Northern dwarf siren



Length 4–9 in (10–22 cm)
Habit Wholly aquatic
Breeding Not known season
Status Least concern

Location S.E. USA



This small, eel-like siren is brown or black above, with one or more yellow or tan stripes along its body. Its forelimbs are small, each with 3 toes, and it has no hind limbs. The feathery

external gills help it breathe in water with a low oxygen content. This nocturnal amphibian inhabits swamps, ditches, and marshes, and estivates in mud during the dry season. It feeds on aquatic invertebrates, and is preyed upon by wading birds, water snakes, alligators, and turtles. The female attaches her eggs to water plants.



Batrachuperus pinchonii

Western Chinese mountain salamander



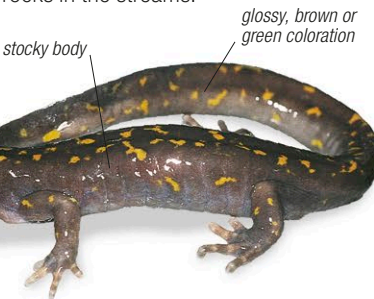
Length 5–6 in (13–15 cm)
Habit Largely aquatic
Breeding Spring and summer season
Status Vulnerable

Location E. Tibet, China (Sichuan Province)



This robust amphibian has a pale brown or olive-green body, usually with darker spots, and

about 12 costal grooves along its flanks. It has short legs, with 4 toes on each limb, and a short tail that is flattened from side to side. This nocturnal animal lives in cold, clear, fast-flowing streams at high altitudes. Since there are few fish in these cold water courses, the eggs and larvae of this salamander are relatively safe from predators. The female lays 7–12 eggs in hollows under rocks in the streams.



stocky body

glossy, brown or green coloration

Cryptobranchus alleganiensis

Hellbender



Length 12–29 in (30–74 cm)
Habit Wholly aquatic
Breeding Fall season
Status Near threatened

Location E. USA



The hellbender is the only North American member of the giant salamander family—a group of 3 species notable for their wrinkled skin and exceptional size. Green, brown, or gray, often with darker spots, it has a head flattened like a spade, small eyes, and a long, paddlelike tail. It is nocturnal, and uses its head to dig out crayfish and other prey. The hellbender has a strong bite, and its skin secretes a noxious slime. Females lay their eggs in fall, and the males guard them until they hatch.

Necturus maculosus

Mudpuppy



Length 11¼–19½ in (29–49 cm)
Habit Wholly aquatic
Breeding Fall in north, winter in south season
Status Least concern

Location S. Canada, C. and E. USA



The mudpuppy has a long, cylindrical body, a flattened tail, feathery external gills, and 2 pairs of limbs, each with 4-toed feet. It is brown, gray, or black, usually with black spots and blotches. An inhabitant of freshwater habitats, it feeds on small animals, mainly at night. Females lay their eggs in early summer under rocks and logs, then guard them

Andrias japonicus

Japanese giant salamander



Length Up to 4½ ft (1.4 m)
Habit Wholly aquatic
Breeding Late summer season
Status Near threatened

Location Japan



Along with the Chinese giant salamander (*Andrias davidianus*), the Japanese giant salamander is the largest amphibian in the world. It is gray or brown, with a flattened body, small eyes, and sprawling legs. Its head and throat are warty, and the skin along its sides is deeply folded—a characteristic that helps it to absorb oxygen from the surrounding water. It is active mainly at night, feeding on fish, worms, and crustaceans. During the breeding season, the male digs a spawning pit, in which the female deposits strings of about 500 eggs. The male then guards the eggs, aggressively fending off predators. Japanese giant salamanders can live for over 50 years, but they are a traditional delicacy, and have become increasingly rare.

ADAPTABLE GILLS



small front legs

red external gills

The gills of the mudpuppy adapt to the oxygen content of the animal's habitat. In cool, oxygen-rich water they are usually small, but in stagnant, warm water they tend to be considerably larger.

BODY SHAPE

The flattened, eel-like body shape of the mudpuppy enables it to burrow under rocks and logs.



dark blotches

slimy skin

until they hatch, about 2 months later. The mudpuppy has disappeared from many polluted or silted rivers.